Choosing between options

Which option should we recommend, and why is it better than the alternatives?



Today

By the end of today, you will have

Appraised your options against explicit criteria, estimated cost per outcome, tested sensitivity, applied the public value test, and chosen.

- Choose and weight explicit criteria, including distribution and feasibility.
- Score each option, and the baseline, with a reason for every score.
- Estimate rough cost per unit of outcome and test whether the ranking depends on assumptions.
- Test the preferred option for public value, legitimacy and support, and operational capacity.

Competencies: G3 · G4 · G5 · J2

Session plan

10 min	**Opening problem**
20 min	**Concept: criteria and weights**
20 min	**Demonstration: Madhyapur appraisal**
35 min	**Activity: decision committee**
15 min	**Own case: options appraisal**
10 min	**Pod check of appraisals**
10 min	**Exit task**

Opening problem

- **Option A is cheaper. Option B helps the poorest households more. Option C is what the councillors want. Which do you recommend?**

Write your answer and the criterion you used. Did you use only one?

Criteria for appraising public options

Criterion	Question
Effectiveness	How much would it change the outcome, and how confident are we?
Cost	What does it cost, to whom, and over what period?
Administrative feasibility	Can the institutions that must deliver it actually do so?
Political feasibility	Can it win and keep enough support?
Distribution	Who gains, who pays, and who is left out?
Risk and reversibility	What could go wrong, and can we change course?

State weights openly. Weights are value judgements: make them visible rather than hiding them in scores.

Options appraisal: Madhyapur (illustrative scores, 1 to 5)

Criterion (weight)	Baseline	A. Pay for separation	B. Pickers' partnership	C. Enforcement drive
Effectiveness (30%)	1	4	3	2
Cost: 5 is cheapest (20%)	5	2	3	3
Administrative feasibility (15%)	5	3	3	2
Political feasibility (15%)	4	3	4	2
Distribution (10%)	1	3	5	2
Risk and reversibility (10%)	4	2	3	3
Weighted score	3.15	3.00	3.35	2.30

Illustrative. Every score needs a written reason. The baseline scores well because it is cheap and easy, which is why weights must be argued, not assumed.

Cost per outcome, roughly (illustrative)

Option	Annual cost	Extra households separating	Cost per extra household	Key assumption
A	Rs 6 crore	60,000	about Rs 1,000	Crews keep streams apart once paid to
B	Rs 3 crore	35,000	about Rs 860	The cooperative can scale to all pilot wards
C	Rs 2 crore	10,000	about Rs 2,000	Enforcement is sustained beyond year one

Illustrative figures. The point is the reasoning: state the assumption that drives each estimate, and round honestly.

Does the ranking survive a different assumption?

Base case

- Effectiveness weighted 30 per cent, cost 20 per cent
- B ranks first, the baseline second, A third
- B costs about Rs 860 per extra household

Sensitivity tests

- Effectiveness 40 per cent, cost 10 per cent: B still first, A rises to second
- If the cooperative reaches only half the wards, B's cost per household roughly doubles
- B is robust to the weights but sensitive to the cooperative's reach

Report what the recommendation depends on. Here: the cooperative's capacity to scale.

The public value test: option B

V

Public value

Does it improve outcomes people value? More recovered waste; safer, recognised work for pickers.

L

Legitimacy and support

Will council, residents and workers back it? Likely, if relations with the contractor are managed.

C

Operational capacity

Can it be delivered? It depends on the cooperative and on ward sorting centres. This is the weakest leg.

Name the weakest leg and say how the plan will strengthen it.

Comprehensive or incremental?

1

Comprehensive

Choose the best option across the board and implement it at once. Attractive on paper; risky when knowledge and capacity are limited.

2

Incremental

Choose a good option, try it, learn and adjust. Madhyapur: start B in ten wards, build processing, then move to A when the contract is renewed.

The Madhyapur recommendation is a sequence: B now, A at renewal. A combined, sequenced option is often the strongest.

A thinker for your case

Mark Moore, with Charles Lindblom

Creating Public Value (1995); "The Science of 'Muddling Through'" (1959)

Moore's strategic triangle asks public managers to align value, support and capacity. Lindblom argued that comparing a few options step by step is often wiser than searching for a comprehensive best.

The question it puts to your case

Does the option create public value, can it win legitimacy and support, and is there the capacity to deliver it?

Answer it in one sentence in your workbook today.

Activity: The government decision committee

Defend options before officials who judge them by different criteria.

Scenario

Pods present three options for the Day 16 primary healthcare case to a committee of four: a finance officer focused on cost, an implementing official focused on capacity, a representative of affected citizens focused on distribution, and a political adviser focused on support. The budget can fund one option fully or two partially.

What to do

1. Each pod prepares a one-minute case for each of its three options.
2. Committee members question each option on their own criterion only.
3. The committee states its weights, then scores the options.
4. The pod revises its preferred option in response.
5. Debrief: whose criterion decided the outcome?

Time 35 minutes

Groups Pods present in turn; four volunteers form the committee

Output A committee decision with explicit weights

Your case: Worksheet 7.2

Options appraisal

1. Choose your criteria and weights, and write why each weight is what it is.
2. Score each option and the baseline, with a reason for every score.
3. Estimate rough cost per unit of outcome, stating the assumptions.
4. Change one weight or assumption and see whether the ranking holds.
5. Test your preferred option on the public value triangle and name the weakest leg.

Hand in

Worksheet 7.2 by the start of Day 18. Pods check each other's appraisals in the last ten minutes of today's session; the instructor comments in writing before Day 18.

Quality check

Weights stated and argued.

Tag every claim in your Analyst's Ledger: fact, inference, assumption or hypothesis.

What to take away

1. State criteria and weights openly: weights are value judgements.
2. Every score needs a reason, and the baseline must be scored too.
3. Estimate cost per outcome roughly, and say what drives it.
4. Test the choice: sensitivity, and value, support and capacity.

Exit task Write the one assumption your recommendation depends on most.

Before the next session

Independent work

Write your recommendation in one paragraph: what, by whom, by when, at what cost, and what it depends on. About 45 minutes.

Read

Moore, Creating Public Value (1995), the chapter on defining public value.

Next

Day 18: Designing for delivery

Tomorrow: turning the choice into a plan that can actually be delivered.